

WE DECIDE

What is served, when, and where.

YOUR TODDLER DECIDES

Whether they eat, and how much.

The six rules

- 1 3 meals + 2 snacks**, every 2.5–3 hrs. Water only between.
- 2 No grazing.** Milk with meals, ~16 oz a day max.
- 3 Family style.** Bowls on the table; they serve themselves.
- 4 One safe food on every plate** — part of the meal, not a rescue.
- 5 No short-order cooking.** One meal for everyone.
- 6 Say nothing about their eating.** Good or bad.

DO

- + **Describe** — “crunchy and sweet” — don’t sell it.
- + **Eat it yourself**, visibly, with enjoyment.
- + **Accept “no” the first time.**
- + **Let them spit it out.** Escape routes make trying safe.
- + **Serve a one-bite portion** next to a favorite.
- + **End at ~20 minutes**, calmly.

DON'T

- **No dessert as payment.**
- **No praise for eating.** It makes food a performance.
- **No negotiating bites.**
- **No backup meal.**
- **No hiding veg** as the main plan.
- **Don't let one rough meal change anything.**

Bridges from current favorites

Cottage cheese → ricotta → soft egg curds → scrambled egg → egg salad

Pizza sauce → marinara dip → tomato soup → roasted tomato → raw

Veg: roasted sweet potato → carrot → broccoli → peas → raw

Pizza → minced pepperoni → meatball → chicken meatball → cut chicken

Peanut butter → on crackers → on apple → as a dip → hummus

Fruit: applesauce → cooked apple → raw; freeze-dried berry → fresh

Progress — every step counts

on the table → on their plate → touches it → smells it → licks it → spits it out → one bite → eats it

CALL THE PEDIATRICIAN IF

Fewer than ~20 **accepted foods** or the list is shrinking · a whole food group or texture refused · **gagging, choking, or vomiting** at meals · pocketing food · weight loss or falling off the growth curve · panic at the sight of food · signs of reflux, constipation, or pain. **Ask for a pediatric feeding therapist (SLP or OT).** Early help is short help.

It takes 10–15 tries. Count how often we serve it — not how much gets eaten.

Ellyn Satter's Division of Responsibility · food chaining
General guidance, not medical advice